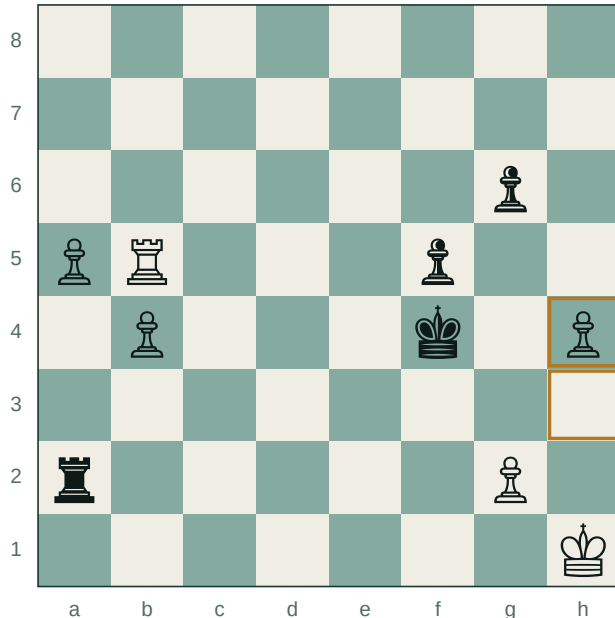


Mate in three: Black, move 39

Mate in three

Black to move



Previous move: 39.h4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

39...Kg3 40. Rd5 Ra1+ 41. Rd1 Rxd1#

39...Kg3 The king moves from f4 to g3. Recorded reply: **40.Rd5**.

40...Ra1+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. Recorded reply: **41.Rd1**.

41...Rxd1# Mate: rook on d1 gives check; White has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on h1. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

CHECKPOINT

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Rook on d1. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not stop at a promising check. The final mating position must still be legal after every intervening move.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Longer mating lines require accurate visualization. Track the king's square, opened lines, and every sacrificed piece through the entire sequence.

HOW TO LOOK

Work backward from a mating pattern, then calculate forward with the opponent choosing the strongest defense.

The defending king is on h1. Geometrically undefended: rook on b5. Check for tactical protection.